

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

When Things Fall Apart
Heart Advice for Difficult Times
How to...be mortal

June 22nd, 2025



*Saint Brendan [484-577] Stained Glass
by Harry Clarke [1889-1931]*

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
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The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Emma Whitten, Guest Organist

Prelude and Fugue in B major, Op. 7, No. 1 - Marcel Dupré (1886–1971)
Retrospection ("An Elf on a Moonbeam") - Florence Price (1887–1953)
Sonata duodecima, Op. 16, No. 12 - Isabella Leonarda (1620–1704)
Prelude on "Veni Creator Spiritus" - Libby Larsen (b. 1950)
Fantasia super "Komm, Heiliger Geist," BWV 651 - Johann Sebastian Bach (1685–1750)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack

Words of Gathering

Rev. Tanaka Pack & Lauren Seely

We live our lives with little regard
for the import of each moment.
They come to us
in regular and rapid succession,
and we live through each of them into the next.
A simple, ongoing process
into which our lives are set at birth
and through which we will proceed unto our deaths.

Yet in each moment resides incredible power –
new life,
healing,
opportunity,
and we, who move near-blindly through them
look to one another as we gather,
that we may do together
the work of opening one another
to the mysteries of this life,
and our potential of living to the fullest.

Today, may our singing be filled with transformation,
may our words reflect the yearning of our hearts,
and may the Spirit of Life that builds within us as we gather,
hallow each and every passing moment
we know here together.

In expectation of what shall be,
we ask all of this. [adapt/gv/lvf]

Please stand as you are able, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

Listen, Now We Tell a Mystery

BEECHER

Listen, now we tell a mystery, told by prophets long before;
We will all be changed forever; pain and death will be no more.
With the Spirit's healing power faith becomes reality;
We proclaim immortal glory far beyond what we can see.

Sound the transformation trumpet; sing a song of victory;
Heaven and earth join in the chorus, welcoming new liberty.
Ever changing, ever growing, we claim all we're meant to be,
Joining in the Spirit's work of setting all creation free.

Celebrate new life eternal, springing from Creative Love;
Resurrection brings rejoicing all around us and above.
With the liberating Spirit, we will soar on angel wings,
Ever onward, ever forward, as the world in triumph rings.

Lyrics by Jann Aldredge-Clanton

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Tanaka Pack

O Great life-giving Spirit
whose voice we hear in the winds
and whose warm breath gives life to all the world –
Hear us...
one eight-billionth of the humans on planet earth.

*Help us to remember
we are a part of the universe
as natural and necessary as the rocks,
the trees, and the birds,
perhaps no more important – nor any less.*

Let us walk in beauty, Spirit of Life,
let our spirits see the dynamic quality of life in all that exists
with no prejudice or malice toward any creation.
May we begin to remember who we are in the natural order of life
as we stand in our own shallow pools of time.

*May we come to know, O Spirit,
what time it is
in our lives and in all life.
Amen.*

[adapt/fpeavey]

***Introit**

"God Be Merciful"

ANDREW GANT

Katelyn Dietz and Rohan Ramanan, *Soloists*

***The Lord's Prayer**

Lauren Seely

*Our God, who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy Name,
thy kingdom come, thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.*

*Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.
And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.
For thine is the kingdom,
and the power, and the glory,
forever.
Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Life shines out at us from even the shadowed corners
beckoning us to be drawn into its truth.
With classic precision,
the options for peace are placed before us.

We hesitate, laugh at the possibilities,
shrug off the responsibilities
and go about our merry way,
happy to leave whatever
those shadows may have brought.

In this hour, we turn toward those corners,
we sink into their deep mysteries,
open ourselves to life's possibilities,
yearn after its truths
and notice, feel the weight of, and accept the responsibility
life has placed upon us.

*We are called to see with eyes that can see,
hear with ears that can hear,
and live our lives as those filled with purpose.*

This morning, may the Peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Words from Our Religious Tradition *from Deuteronomy & the Psalms*

Lauren Seely

Singing Of Psalm 90

NICK STRIMPLE

"God, Thou Hast Been Our Dwelling Place" from *Prayers In A Time Of Plague*
Laude

For the Word of God in Scripture.
For the Word of God in Song.
For the Word of God within us.
For the Word of God among us.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayers of Our Hearts

That truth has been inscribed into our hearts
and into the hearts of every human being,
there to be read and revered,
Thanks be to you, O God.

That there are ways of seeing and sensitivities of knowing
hidden deep in the palace of the soul,
waiting to be discovered,
ready to be set free.
Thanks be to you.

Open our senses to wisdom's inner promptings
that we may give voice to what we hear in our souls
and be changed for the healing of the world.
That we may listen for truth in every living soul
and be changed for the well-being of the world.
Amen and Amen.

J. Phillip Newell, Prayer for Wisdom

Meditation Anthem

"I've Got It Bad, And That Ain't Good"
Marc Doten, *Piano*

DUKE ELLINGTON

Sermon

How to...be mortal

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Tanaka Pack

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how it's given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

"#UnitedWeDream"
Cathedral Choir

MELISSA DUNPHY

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Prayer of Offering**

Lauren Seely

For all that has been and for all that will be,
we give you our thanks, O God.

May these gifts be used to nurture the life
around us and among us,
as our lives grow
by the generosity of our hands,
and our hearts.

May it ever be so.
May it ever be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Tanaka Pack

Words of Blessing

Mysteries, Yes by Mary Oliver

Rev. Fregin

Truly, we live with mysteries too marvelous
to be understood.

How grass can be nourishing in the
mouths of lambs.
How rivers and stones are forever
in allegiance with gravity
while we ourselves dream of rising.
How two hands touch and the bonds
will never be broken.
How people come, from delight or the
scars of damage,
to the comfort of a poem.

Let me keep my distance, always, from those
who think they have the answers.

Let me keep company always with those who say
'Look!' and laugh in astonishment,
and bow their heads.

-Mary Oliver

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

"Song of Hope"
Cathedral Choir

AVISHAI COHEN

*Hymn for the Journey

How Deep the Silence of the Soul

KINGSFOLD

How deep the silence of the soul that lives within your grace.
How full the gratitude of heart in your abiding place.
What rich serenity is found, what courage and release
when Wisdom teaches us to seek the gentle path to peace.

Like unseen chimes on moving air, like warm and morning sun,
Like glad-denying, green-ing, grow-ing things, like trees with blooms begun.
Such is your presence in our lives, you touch without a trace,
until we turn and find ourselves held fast in your embrace.

-Lyrics by Sylvia Dunstan

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Emma Whitten, *Guest Organist*

Fanfare - C.S. Lang (1891–1971)

Inside The Music

"This week we feature pieces that were written in response to challenging moments in history. Cohen's "Song Of Hope" reflects on the ongoing Middle East crisis. Dunphy's "#UnitedWeDream" was written in response to the ongoing struggle of Dreamers and immigrants to the U.S. Strimple's "Psalm 90" was written during the Covid lockdown. We had the privilege of premiering it, and it has become an important part of our repertoire. And Gant's "God Be Merciful" and Ellington's "I've Got It Bad, And That Ain't Good" reflect the day to day challenges of being human. Musically, "Song Of Hope" is a light jazz ballad. As it softly grooves, the lyrics remind us how humble we truly are, but how much we shape the world. The chorus simply states over and again "this is a song of hope." The brevity is the statement. It brings us back to focus on hope, a common goal across humanity. "#UnitedWeDream," like so many of Dunphy's pieces, centers on a heart-stirring, almost folk-like, melody. It says over and again "this is where we belong." We are stirred to compassion and caring in its caressing sweetness. At the Golden Mean she shifts the key a major third away, and contrasts the previous energy with the word "resist!" followed by "fight tooth and nail!" in Spanish. It's a brief, but powerful, explication, and a meaningful reflection on this current moment in time. Marc was going to play Ellington's "I Got It Bad" in February, but got sick. I'm glad we're getting to hear it this week. The lyrics, which we won't hear today, flow from the voice of someone who has given over their power to the vision of another. They are so lost in their version of reality which doesn't align with the reality of others that they can't function. It's both a love song and a life song. So often we give over our power to others out of fear or convenience. The wistful release that can come from that choice can feel edifying in the short term, but causes premature decay in the end. Rather than reshaping our imaginative reality, perhaps finding peace in the midst of this objective reality is the trick. All of this music has within it a peaceful center, and yet it surrounds that peace with complication. Just as in life, these pieces remind us of what we can find even within disruption." – Dr. David Harris